

Yining Ding

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EDUCATION

Ph.D., Psychological & Brain Sciences

Anticipated May 2027

Washington University in St. Louis

GPA: 4.00/4.00

Advisor: Jeffrey M. Zacks

Additional Training:

- Cognitive, Computational, and Systems Neuroscience (CCSN) Pathway (completed)
- Graduate Certificate in Quantitative Data Analysis (completed)

M.A., Psychological & Brain Sciences

May 2024

Washington University in St. Louis

GPA: 4.00/4.00

Advisor: Jeffrey M. Zacks

Master's Thesis: *Temporal order memory in naturalistic events is influenced by semantic knowledge and hierarchical event structure*

B.S., Cognitive Studies (Highest Honors), summa cum laude

May 2022

Minors: Computer Science, German Studies

GPA: 3.97/4.00

Vanderbilt University

Advisor: Daniel T. Levin

Honors Thesis: *The influence of sequence reversal on event perception*

HONORS & AWARDS

WashU P&BS Departmental Research Grant (\$600)	2025
Psychonomic Society Graduate Student Travel Award (\$750)	2024
WashU P&BS Departmental Research Grant (\$960)	2024
WashU P&BS Departmental Travel Grant	2022 – 2026
Highest Honors in Cognitive Studies	2022
Undergraduate Academic Achievement Award in German Studies	2022
Vanderbilt University Summer Research Program Stipend (\$5000)	2021
McTyeire Citizen Award for Immersive Language Learning	2021
Dean's List, Peabody College	2018 – 2022

PUBLICATIONS

Ding, Y., Zacks, J. M. (2026). Semantic knowledge and hierarchical event structure can scaffold memory for temporal order. *Journal of Experimental Psychology: Learning, Memory, and Cognition*.

Ding, Y., Alperin, D. R., Zacks, J. M. (2026). Aging and temporal order memory in naturalistic Events. *Psychology and Aging*.

MANUSCRIPTS UNDER REVIEW & IN PREPARATION

(*equal contribution)

Ding, Y.*, Wellons, B. M.*, Bezdek, M. A., Fox, C., Wahlheim, C. N., Zacks, J. M. (in prep). The effect of episodic and schematic event changes on event segmentation and memory.

Ding, Y., Nguyen T. T., Zacks, J. M. (in prep). Neural state segmentation in naturalistic goal-directed activities.

Ding, Y., Zacks, J. M. (in prep). Hierarchical structure in event perception and memory: A review of the compartmentalization mechanism.

Su, X., **Ding, Y.**, Zacks, J. M. (in prep). Segmentation as proactive control: Gaze entropy reveals rising uncertainty prior to event boundaries.

Topçu, M., Boduroglu, A., **Ding, Y.**, Alperin, D., Batiashvili, N., Wertsch, J., Roediger, R. (in prep). Collective anxiety, memory, and future thinking in the context of 2024 US presidential election.

POSTERS AND PRESENTATIONS

(*equal contribution)

(*^undergraduate mentee*)

Ding, Y.*, Wellons, B. M.*, Bezdek, M. A., Fox, C., Wahlheim, C. N., Zacks, J. M. (2026). The effect of episodic change and schematic coherence on event perception and memory. Poster to be presented at Context and Episodic Memory Symposium (CEMS) 2026, Philadelphia, PA

Su, X., **Ding, Y.**, Zacks, J. M. (2026). Segmentation as proactive Control: Gaze entropy reveals rising uncertainty prior to event boundaries. Poster to be presented at Annual Meeting of the Vision Sciences Society (VSS) 2026, St. Pete Beach, FL

[^]Zhou, W., **Ding, Y.**, Zacks, J. M. (2026). Linking neural state segmentation to changes in environmental features during naturalistic viewing. Poster Presentation at WashU Spring 2026 Mind, Brain, Behavior Research Symposium, St. Louis, MO

[^]Han, R., **Ding, Y.**, Zacks, J. M. (2026). Automated free recall scoring for naturalistic videos using large language models. Poster Presentation at WashU Spring 2026 Undergraduate Research Symposium, St. Louis, MO

Ding, Y., Alperin, D. R., Zacks, J. M. (2026). Aging and temporal order memory in naturalistic events. Poster Presentation at WashU 31st Annual Graduate Research Symposium, St. Louis, MO

Ding, Y., Nguyen T. T., Zacks, J. M. (2026). Neural state segmentation in naturalistic goal-directed activities. Poster Presentation at Cognitive Neuroscience Society 2026 Annual Meeting, Vancouver, BC, Canada

Ding, Y., Alperin, D. R., Zacks, J. M. (2025). Aging and temporal order memory in naturalistic events. Poster Presentation at Psychonomic Society 66th Annual Meeting, Denver, CO

Ding, Y., Alperin, D. R., Zacks, J. M. (2025). Aging and temporal order memory in naturalistic events. Poster Presentation at Cognitive Neuroscience Society 2025 Annual Meeting, Boston, MA

Ding, Y., Alperin, D. R., Zacks, J. M. (2024). Readers use larger temporal structure to remember specific event order. Poster Presentation at Psychonomic Society 65th Annual Meeting, New York City, NY

Ding, Y., Alperin, D. R., Zacks, J. M. (2024). Temporal order memory in naturalistic events is influenced by semantic knowledge and hierarchical event structure. Poster Presentation at Cognitive Neuroscience Society 2024 Annual Meeting, Toronto, ON, Canada

Ding, Y., Alperin, D. R., Zacks, J. M. (2023). Temporal order memory in naturalistic events is influenced by semantic knowledge and hierarchical event structure. Poster Presentation at Psychonomic Society 64th Annual Meeting, San Francisco, CA

Ding, Y., Lee, M. J., & Levin, D. T. (2022). Failures to detect reversed events persist without disruptions and do not impact event memory or event segmentation. Poster Presentation at Psychonomic Society 63rd Annual Meeting, Boston, MA

Ding, Y., & Levin, D. T. (2022). The influence of sequence reversal on visual event perception. Poster presented at Vanderbilt University Psychology Day Poster Session, Nashville, TN

Ding, Y., & Levin, D. T. (2021). The influence of sequence reversal on visual event perception. Poster presented at Vanderbilt University Undergraduate Research Fair, Nashville, TN

Ding, Y., & Koepnick, L.P. (2022). Soccer Culture in Dalian: A Multimedia Essay. Multimedia website presented at Vanderbilt University Undergraduate Creative Expression Showcase, Nashville, TN

TALKS

Ding, Y., Alperin, D. R., Zacks, J. M., (2026). Semantic knowledge and hierarchical event structure can scaffold memory for temporal order in younger and older adults. Context and Episodic Memory Symposium (CEMS) 2026, Philadelphia, PA, USA

Ding, Y., Alperin, D. R., Zacks, J. M., (2026). Aging and temporal order memory in naturalistic events. Lifespan Development Summit 2026, Department of Psychological and Brain Sciences, Washington University in St. Louis, MO, USA

Ding, Y., Nguyen T. T., Zacks, J. M., (2026). Neural state segmentation in naturalistic goal-directed activities. Brain, Behavior, & Cognition Brownbag, Department of Psychological and Brain Sciences, Washington University in St. Louis, MO, USA

Ding, Y., Zacks, J. M., (2025). Semantic knowledge and hierarchical event structure can scaffold memory for temporal order. Brain, Behavior, & Cognition Brownbag, Department of Psychological and Brain Sciences, Washington University in St. Louis, MO, USA

Ding, Y., Alperin, D. R., Zacks, J. M., (2025). Aging and temporal order memory in naturalistic Events. Aging & Development Brownbag, Department of Psychological and Brain Sciences, Washington University in St. Louis, MO, USA

Ding, Y., (2025). Story of your life: How your brain edits and scripts memory of time. Dean's Award for Graduate Research Excellence, Washington University in St. Louis, MO, USA

Topçu, M., Boduroglu, A., **Ding, Y.,** Alperin, D., Batiashvili, N., Wertsch, J., Roediger, R. (2025). Collective memory and collective anxiety regarding the 2024 US elections. Society of Experimental Psychologists Annual Meeting 2025, St. Louis, MO, USA

Topçu, M., Boduroglu, A., **Ding, Y.,** Alperin, D., Batiashvili, N., Wertsch, J., Roediger, R. (2025). Collective anxiety, memory, and future thinking in the context of US presidential elections. Parallel Session 10 at Society for Applied Research in Memory and Cognition (SARMAC) 15th Biennial Meeting, County Kildare, Ireland

Ding, Y., Zacks, J. M. (2024). Semantic knowledge and hierarchical structure scaffold event memory. Symposium "Events and the Temporal Organization of Memory" at Association for Psychological Science Annual Convention 2024, San Francisco, CA, USA

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Graduate Researcher <i>Washington University in St. Louis</i> Advisor: Dr. Jeffrey M. Zacks Dynamic Cognition Lab	2022-Present
Undergraduate Honors Thesis Student <i>Vanderbilt University</i> Advisor: Dr. Daniel T. Levin Levin Lab	2020-2022
Undergraduate Research Assistant <i>Vanderbilt University</i> Advisor: Dr. Ashleigh F. Maxcey Maxcey Memory Lab	2019-2020
Undergraduate Research Assistant (Remote) <i>Peking University</i> Advisor: Dr. Yinyin Zang Intervention, Protection, and Promotion Lab	2020-2021
Undergraduate Independent Research Student <i>Vanderbilt University</i> Advisor: Dr. Lutz P. Koepnick Department of German, Russian, and East European Studies	2020-2022

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Co-Instructor, Cognitive Psychology (Psych 360) <i>Department of Psychological & Brain Sciences, Washington University in St. Louis</i>	Summer 2025
Assistant in Instruction, Cognitive Neuroscience (Psych 3604) <i>Department of Psychological & Brain Sciences, Washington University in St. Louis</i> - Led two exam review sessions - Guest lecture: Declarative Memory	Spring 2025
Assistant in Instruction, Introductory Psychological Statistics (Psych 300) <i>Department of Psychological & Brain Sciences, Washington University in St. Louis</i> - Led three exam review sessions - Guest lecture: Hierarchical Linear Regression	Spring 2024
Assistant in Instruction, Introduction to Psychology (Psych 100B) <i>Department of Psychological & Brain Sciences, Washington University in St. Louis</i> Guest lecture: Sleep and Memory	Fall 2023
Teaching Assistant & Grader, Discrete Structures (CS 2212) <i>Department of Computer Science, Vanderbilt University</i>	Spring 2022

ADDITIONAL TRAINING

Graduate Certificate in Quantitative Data Analysis, <i>WashU</i>	2022-2026
Cognitive, Computational, and Systems Neuroscience (CCSN) Pathway, <i>WashU</i>	2022-2026

Computational Cognitive Neuroscience Summer School (CCNSS), <i>Cold Spring Harbor Asia</i>	2023
Exploring Practices in the Classroom (EPIC) Program, <i>WashU Center of Teaching and Learning</i>	2023
Media and International Relationship Summer School, <i>Peking University</i>	2019

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Summer Research Fellow, The Storytelling Lab	2023
<i>Incubator for Transdisciplinary Futures, Washington University in St. Louis</i>	
Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) Intern	2020-2021
<i>Intel Corporation, Dalian, China</i>	

SERVICE AND OUTREACH

Grad Bridge Program Peer Lead, <i>WashU College of Art & Sciences</i>	2026
Fellow of Graduate Advisory Board, <i>WashU Center for Career Engagement</i>	2025-2026
Fellow of Libraries Student Advisory Group (LSAG), <i>WashU Libraries</i>	2024-2025
Discussion Leader of Graduate Teaching Workshop, <i>WashU Center of Teaching and Learning</i>	2024
Volunteer Teacher, <i>Amazing Brain Carnival Demonstration, Saint Louis Science Center</i>	2024, 2025
Chair of Brownbag Committee, <i>WashU Psychology Graduate Student Association</i>	2023
Member of Diversity Committee, <i>WashU Psychology Graduate Student Association</i>	2022
Selections Chair & Orientation Leader, <i>Vanderbilt International Student Orientation</i>	2019-2022
Peabody Academic Leader, <i>Peabody College of Education, Vanderbilt University</i>	2019-2022
Vice President & Soprano Singer, <i>Vanderbilt University Concert Choir</i>	2018-2022
Vice President & Volunteer Teacher of Music, <i>Vanderbilt Music Outreach</i>	2019-2022
Volunteer Teacher of Neuroscience, <i>Vanderbilt Interaxon</i>	2018-2019
External Staff in the Innovations Team, <i>World Economic Forum Summer Davos</i>	2019

AD HOC REVIEWING

Psychological Sciences; Cognition; Cognitive Psychology; Psychological Bulletin & Review; Nature Communications; Behavioral and Brain Functions; Neuropsychologia; Trends in Cognitive Sciences; Journal of Experimental Psychology: General

MENTORING EXPERIENCE

Sandra Xie (<i>Research Assistant</i>)	2026
Wenhao Zhou (<i>Mind, Brain, and Behavior Individual Project Student</i>)	2025-2026
Oliver Gu (<i>SURGE Individual Project Student; Research Assistant</i>)	2025-2026
Michelle Han (<i>Individual Project Student</i>)	2025-2026
Hengchang Lu (<i>Individual Project Student</i>)	2024
Devon Alperin (<i>Research Assistant</i>)	2023-2024

ACADEMIC MEMBERSHIPS

International Society to Advance Alzheimer's Research and Treatment (ISTAART)	2026
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American Psychological Association Division 20 (Adult Development and Aging)	2025
Cognitive Neuroscience Society	2023
Psychonomic Society	2022
Delta Phi Alpha National German Honor Society	2022
Psi Chi International Honor Society in Psychology	2020

LANGUAGES & SKILLS

Languages: Chinese (native), English (fluent), German (intermediate, B2), Japanese (basic)

Technical: R, Python, MATLAB, Java, C++, SR Research Experiment Builder, JASP, SPSS, jsPsych, Qualtrics, NVivo, Adobe Premiere